the Pentagon Papers. Giving it to Dan had symbolic value for us. We also knew he could be trusted to publish the whole lot during a crisis.

You have to realise, the material did not only have great value philosophically. If we had wanted to, we could probably have sold the cables for millions of dollars – indeed, I have been offered money for them even after we started to publish – but we do not operate like that. Still, I wanted to impress upon our partners the value of this material, so that they would appreciate what they were dealing with when we negotiated the conditions under which it might be released. The *Guardian* was still the right paper to work with on this material and I put my worries aside. I asked for a signed letter from the paper's editor, Alan Rusbridger, guaranteeing that the material would be kept strictly confidential, that nothing would be published from it until we were ready to go, and that it would not be stored on a computer that was connected to the Internet or any internal network. Rusbridger agreed and we signed the letter. In return, I produced an encrypted disk with a password and they had the material. At which point the senior news reporter went off on holiday to Scotland, all bonhomie and jollity, ready to read the material and keep in touch about the future plan.

With the Swedish case now in the air, there was a definite sense of gossiping schoolgirls among the media partners. It amazed me, because many of them are investigative reporters, and you'd imagine they knew something about smears and hysteria when it came to political outcasts. A man, for example, who worked for the Bureau of Investigative Journalism suddenly told his colleagues he wouldn't 'appear on stage with a rapist', and the fact that the papers didn't want their logo on the banner at the press conference – well, it was the same old credulousness and suspicion. Some of those men have more skeletons in their closets than Highgate Cemetery but they dived on my troubles with an unmistakeable glee. None of them asked me how it came about, or how I was, or whether I needed anything: they simply responded as if the creepy allegations were 'smoke' that could not possibly exist, despite everything their experience told them, 'without fire'. Such people sit in judgement all their lives, hoping against hope that no one will ever turn the lamp on them. And of course no one ever does, by and large, because these men are the media, and no Fleet Street editor was ever known to dish on another.

Having schmoozed their way to several scoops off the back of our organisation, two of these media partners began to behave as if I